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Author(s): David Tracy

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Method as Foundation for Theology: Bernard Lonergan's Option

David Tracy

Much has been rumored and much more, I suspect, will be rumored about Bernard Lonergan's work in progress, *Method in Theology*. It is intended as his major statement on the central question of his own life's work, namely, theological method. A definitive critique of the work will, of course, have to await its completion.¹ In the meantime, however, a number of interested observers have requested some context for understanding the central thrust of Lonergan's work. This article, it is hoped, may help to fill that information gap. Accordingly the article will be principally expository—and that of one central concept in Lonergan's later work: "functional specializations." That concept is, I believe, the key to Lonergan's method in both *Insight* and *Method in Theology* (which could almost be named *Insight II*), and bears careful exposition.

The question, then, is that of theological method. To that question, with increasing frequency, Bernard Lonergan has devoted his major attention from 1959 to the present.² Indeed, the question of method in

¹ This article is a revision of a chapter in the author's forthcoming book, *The Achievement of Bernard Lonergan* (New York, 1970). It is offered in response to several requests for a brief presentation of Lonergan's methodological views, especially in view of the spring 1970 Lonergan congress, where over sixty experts will criticize Lonergan's thought from various perspectives (e.g., Rahner, Schillebeeckx, Ogden, Macquarrie, Gilkey, Metz, Outler, Lindbeck, Grillmeier, Coreth, et al.).

Although actually written over a year ago, the article has been withheld at Father Lonergan's request until Lonergan's own brief exposition of his position on functional specialties is printed in the special Winter 1969 "method" issue of *Gregorianum*. The present article attempts, therefore, both to expose Lonergan's understanding as accurately as possible and to relate it to Lonergan's prior work and to problematic elements in his thought. My guiding concern has been accuracy of presentation of Lonergan's own position in order to assure that criticisms of it (including my own at the spring congress), whatever their other difficulties, do not simply misinterpret what he is and is not holding.

² The sources for that interest are the series of courses and lectures on the problematics of meaning and method, from the course *De Intellectu et Methodo* (Rome, 1959) through the forthcoming *Method in Theology*. Since it is impossible to paginate the as yet unpublished work *Method in Theology*, the analysis in this section will

the human sciences, in philosophy, and in theology are, for many of their practitioners, the principal question on the present horizon. As the gains of the phenomenological movement have made especially clear, the method employed is the key to all the products of any discipline. For many, “method” tends to become a secondary or even a relatively unimportant problem. It sounds to them (as Gadamer reminds us) as if one were seeking for some new rules (usually logical) that could be followed blindly by any “hewer of wood and drawer of water.”³ Indeed, to many it sounds disturbingly like the last gasp of a dying classical culture. Now, if the contemporary search for method were in fact a search for “new” logical rules whence one may deduce one’s conclusions, then that distrust would be well earned. Yet the fact is that the contemporary search, for method, by and large, is nothing of the sort.

In Lonergan’s case, to be more specific, the methodological search is neither for new rules nor a new “system,” but for a basic pattern whence all rules can be derived. That “pattern” will wish to include the logic of the classical period but must add the contemporary

be from the unpublished manuscript, unless otherwise indicated. From this section on, the analysis adheres fairly closely to the text itself. The footnotes, therefore, will be employed chiefly for references to other confirmatory or exemplary works rather than to the manuscript itself. On the present question, for example, one may note the greater differentiation afforded to the discussion of modern “positive” and historically conscious theology by the distinction between “field” and “subject” specializations.

³ H. G. Gadamer, *Wahrheit und Methode* (Tübingen, 1962), esp. pp. 1–7, 205–18. German interpreters, I suspect, would be tempted to ignore Lonergan’s interest in methodology as yet another example of the “methodologism” of a neo-Kantian variety. This is not the context to calm such suspicions, except to remind interpreters of the critique of Kant by Lonergan (*Insight*, pp. 339–42) and the uniqueness of his notion of transcendental method vis-à-vis the Continental tradition. For further explications on Lonergan vis-à-vis the German tradition, see the essays by Frederick Lawrence and Matthew Lamb on theological method. By way of contrast, see the interpretation of Lonergan in Francis Fiorenza’s otherwise most helpful article, “Karl Rahner and the Kantian Problematic,” in Karl Rahner, *Spirit in The World* (New York, 1968), p. 38. This is not to argue, of course, that Lonergan shares Rahner’s Heideggerian formulation of the Kantian question; but it is to insist that his position cannot be too easily identified with the interpretations of either neo-Kantianism or Marechal. (For an example of the latter difference, see the most authoritative contemporary interpreter of Marechal, J. Donceel, in his preface to the English edition of Coreth’s *Metaphysics* [New York, 1968], pp. 11–12.) On the other hand, the present author would agree (with Fiorenza) that Lonergan’s infrequent references to the dangers of “subjectivism” in phenomenology and “existentialism” is fully inadequate to an interpretation of Heidegger. (See especially Lonergan’s 1957 “Lectures on Mathematical Logic and Existentialism,” where Heidegger is interpreted as an existentialist!)

scientific interest in inquiry, observation, discovery, experiment, synthesis, and verification. It further demands a context wherein the multidimensional levels of meaning (and not only scientific meaning) may find an intrinsic place in the analysis. Yet that latter inclusion need not mean that theological method can only be an “art” and not a “science.” In fact, Lonergan’s own development up to the time of his explicit involvement in the discussion of theological method provides an interesting alternative view to the decreasing returns of the “art” versus “science” impasse. That alternative in its general features will be exposed here in order to aid a more immediate entry into the level of the methodological discussion in Lonergan. It might first be noted that Lonergan is not (even in *Insight*) simply analyzing in an Aristotelian manner a conspicuously successful science (physics) and then judging all other disciplines as scientific or not by their degree of similarity to physics. Indeed, he is not innocent of the gains of the *Geisteswissenschaften* controversy nor of the methodological complexities involved for anyone who recognizes the multidimensional horizon of historical consciousness. Indeed Lonergan’s own development (in *Insight*) has been to derive a preliminary notion of method from the successful empirical sciences (classical and statistical heuristic methods) and to proceed from there to cognitional theory. There he believes he found and thematized the invariant properties of a method that may be called transcendental in *Insight*’s precise sense of the subject’s affirmation of his own consciousness as structural empirically, intelligently, and rationally. From that horizon he moved forward to try to determine the function of transcendental method in its relations to the particular methods of the various sciences.

Within that context, therefore, method is defined by Lonergan as a normative pattern of related and recurrent operations yielding cumulative and progressive results.⁴ That notion of a basic pattern is obviously the fundamental problem. And its nature must be to become a method in the generic sense given above while still maintaining its transcendental character. For basic method for Lonergan cannot be confined categorically to any generic or specific type of result nor to any limited field, but applies instead to all fields where the basic transcendentals (“be intelligent, be reasonable, be responsible, develop and if necessary, change”) are operative. In short, a basic method would apply to all fields where the human mind and its invariant structure,

⁴ Once again, this is Lonergan’s own definition. It will be available in published form in the special “method” issue of *Gregorianum* (Winter 1969).

procedures, and operations are operative. To state the matter rather bluntly, Lonergan would maintain that unless one wishes to claim for theology that its peculiarity as a discipline consists in its being unconcerned with data, uninterested in inquiry, unimpressed by understanding, undisturbed by reflection and verification, and careless of evaluation and decision, then the exigencies of the methodological problem must enter into the theological context as well.

Indeed, the problem of theology at present has often been described as the need to move fully and coherently from classical to historical consciousness, or in the more traditionally Roman Catholic terms familiar to Lonergan, from a notion of theology as “reason illuminated by faith” to “method illuminated by faith.”⁵ That latter notion of method, if we may repeat, can strive for nothing less than a transformation of classical “ratio” by revealing the invariant structures, procedures, and operations of human reason itself. Less than that will either trap theology into a classicism which is elsewhere dead or “free” it for the attractive but inadequate dreams of a whole group of recently arrived romantics unconcerned with the demands of reason, of *theoria*, and a fortiori of method.⁶

The question of method is also relevant to theology insofar as theology, too, has methods which attempt to mediate the Christian experience of the past and to face the exigencies of the present and the future. For however peculiar theological operations may be, theology is, after all, still the work of human minds performing, if Lonergan be correct, the same basic set of operations (experience, understanding, judgment, and decision) in the same basic pattern of relations of common sense and the various sciences. In Lonergan’s own words, “It is true that one attends, inquires, reflects, decides differently in the natural sciences, philosophy, the human sciences and theology. Still there is no transition from attention to inattention, inquiry to indifference, critical to uncritical, responsible to irresponsible.”⁷ And those transcendental imperatives imply not some magical set of rules but a transcendental method which thematizes those imperatives. And

⁵ This formulation may be found in “Theology and Understanding,” in *Collection* (New York, 1967), pp. 121–41.

⁶ For a similar emphasis in Lonergan himself, note that in a later context (on “secularity” and contemporary Christianity) Lonergan is able to emphasize this contemporary need for greater differentiation-integration (not a movement to an undifferentiated state) yet more carefully (see Lonergan’s essay, “The Absence of God in Modern Culture,” in *The Presence and Absence of God*, ed. C. F. Mooney [Bronx, N.Y., 1969]).

⁷ As quoted in the chapter on transcendental method in *Method in Theology*.

since, Lonergan would argue, these transcendental notions are also unrestricted with the unrestrictedness of the pure desire to know intending but never reaching everything about everything, the objects of Christian theology (God and the God-graced world in Jesus Christ), precisely insofar as they are, are not beyond the intentional reach of transcendental method.⁸ On its simplest (if most overlooked) level the problem is as basic as it is obvious: theologians are not exempt from the ordinary human encumbrance of having minds and using them. They could do worse, then, than to try to come to terms with just what that might mean.

To conceive theology in terms of method, therefore, is not to ask a second-level question but a foundational one. It is to conceive theology as a basic pattern of recurrent and related operations proceeding cumulatively and progressively toward an ideal goal. But no single theologian can today hope to know all theology. So highly specialized has the discipline become that no one can hope to attempt more in one lifetime than a mastery of the method and results of a few questions in one of the theological specializations. How, for example, may any one man hope to unite the results of biblical criticism on the “knowledge” of Jesus with the needed philosophical or dogmatic or systematic discussion of the same question? Is there no way out of the temptations to theological totalitarianism which beset each practitioner? Moreover, as the discussions of modernism versus fundamentalism, of liberal theology versus dialectical theology, of Barth versus Bultmann, of “dogmatic” versus “biblical” theology, of the “Greek” versus the “Hebrew” mind, and so on, have made abundantly clear, a foundational problem has surfaced for any honest theologian. That problem can legitimately be named methodological.⁹ In its starkest terms, the theological

⁸ Note the importance of the qualification “intentional.” Hence even Barthian interpreters need not fear that this is yet another Hegelian theological “overreaching” of faith (contrast the claims, for example, with the recent interpretation of Hegel’s philosophical-theological attempt in Emil Fackenheim, *The Religious Dimension in Hegel’s Philosophy* [Bloomington, Ind., 1968]).

⁹ A clarification would be in order here: the methodological problem is “foundational” insofar as otherwise one is left with fairly undifferentiated counterclaims as salvific for theology (e.g., it must be “purely” biblical; or it is useful *only* as a revolutionary force; or the whole tradition is to be interpreted solely in terms of the death of God; or the existential situations of death, guilt [and so on], are no longer relevant to secular man come of age). On the other hand, as will be explained below, “foundational” refers to the theological-functional specialty dealing with the problem of the level of *Existenz* (i.e., man’s contemporary recognition of his time-laden finitude, his historicity), a problem which, in various ways, practically every major theologian since Schleiermacher (including, it seems, the neo-Orthodox and the neo-Thomists, in negative fashion, to be sure) has been attempting to resolve.

problem is this: can the theologian determine a basic pattern for all the patterns of related and recurrent operations involved in the theological task? Can he determine a fundamental theological method which will allow all practitioners to collaborate systematically with one another? Can he ground that pattern in a transcendental method which is not open to fundamental revision?

In the present situation, therefore, Lonergan argues that one finds two fundamental types of specialization: field specialization and subject specialization.¹⁰ Field specialization divides the data to be examined: the Scriptures, the Fathers, the councils, the medieval, Renaissance, Reformation, Enlightenment, modern, or contemporary periods. Within each of these there are further specializations: Scriptures Old Testament, intertestamental period, New Testament; Old Testament laws, prophets, writings, and so on. All these specializations increase their scope as the enormous amount of archaeological and textual materials accumulate into ever more probably accurate critical editions. Subject specialization, on the other hand, performs a different task: it divides and studies the results to be taught in the different departments, subjects, and courses. Thus it is that every complete theological curriculum must include Semitic languages, Hebrew history, religions of the ancient Near East, New Testament theologies, the theologies of the apostolic fathers, the theology of the councils, and so on. When one recognizes both types of specialization as legitimate and indeed necessary, there gradually emerges a recognition of the need to find a way to differentiate the stages in the single process from data to results. Such a need is fulfilled for Lonergan by his development of what he names "functional specialization," a specialization which deals directly neither with data nor results, but seeks to distinguish the stages in the process from data to results. Each stage, moreover, operates functionally¹¹ toward the next, for at each stage there is a different pattern of related and recurrent operations applied to the results of the preceding stage. Each successive stage presupposes the results of the preceding one and complements them by moving them that much closer to the final goal. To clarify this discussion, consult the following diagram of the

¹⁰ The divisions are Lonergan's own formulation. A further clarification may be helpfully employed: Lonergan's notion of functional specialization includes field and subject specialties; field specialties divide the materials of the first phase; subject specialties divide the topics of the second phase. Finally, dialectics and foundations are least divided; research and communications are most divided.

¹¹ The term "functional" is post-*Insight*, yet it is applicable to the levels of consciousness, each of which is functionally related to the next and higher level.

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eightfold functional specialties which define, for Lonergan, the theological task.

Diagram: Combine two phases of theology with four levels of consciousness:

<i>Structure of Consciousness</i>	<i>Mediating Theology</i>	<i>Mediated Theology</i>
Deliberation	(4) Dialectic	Foundations (5)
Judgment	(3) History	Doctrines (6)
Understanding	(2) Interpretation	Systematics (7)
Experience	(1) Research	Communications (8)

The most obvious question occasioned by this outline is, of course, just where does this eightfold list of functional specialties come from? Perhaps a more indirect reply to the question might help before a direct one is offered. In the first place, any theological student will, I believe, have a certain a posteriori familiarity with the list: for he recalls the numerous courses in textual criticism, in exegesis, in history, in what has traditionally been called apologetics (now fundamental theology), in dogmatic theology, in systematic theology, in pastoral theology. He may also recall that usually neither a balance nor an interrelatedness between the specialties is attained in any one theological school. In the Roman Catholic context, for example, if he studied at Louvain he is likely to be “stronger” in textual criticism, exegesis, and history, and “weaker” in dogmatics and systematics. If he studied almost anywhere in Germany or at the Gregorian in Rome, he is likely to be “stronger” in systematics and fundamental and “weaker” in textual criticism and exegesis than his Louvain counterpart. Indeed, in any theological school, the alert student very quickly learns the “strong” points of the curriculum and the “weak” ones. In general, then, I believe that it is fair to say that except in those rare (and probably eschatological) places where the curriculum is balanced and the professors in each discipline highly competent in their own fields and fully conversant with the results in the fields of their colleagues, the student is left with the disconcerting impression that somehow it is up to himself alone to relate and integrate all these disciplines. Nor will he ordinarily find too much encouragement for that task from many of his professors. For he also soon discovers that many of them are so wedded to their own particular disciplines that their lack of interest in other disciplines borders on the patronizing. He may, for example, find exegetes decrying the use of any “profane” philosophy as an intrinsic violation and distortion of the pure word of God. Or he may find systematic theologians blithely using scriptural texts whose scientific

exegesis has no connection at all with the systematic issue in question. Or he may find “pastoral” theologians, innocent of exegesis, history, or systematics alike, insisting that the sole concern of the theologian at present must be to find ways to become “relevant” to the prevailing *Zeitgeist*. Or he may find exegetes or systematic theologians contemptuous of any attempt to communicate their “purely scientific” results in a fashion relevant to the needs of any—and especially this—contemporary culture.

In almost any major theological school there tend to be ragged edges, very little determinateness (sometimes even internecine squabbles among the various theological fiefdoms) and usually only a rough relatedness among the various disciplines. For example, the incomprehension received by the work of Thomas Altizer from many Protestant exegetes and historians or the outright mockery sometimes accorded the sociological concerns of Harvey Cox are but two of the more recent examples of an unfortunately rather widespread phenomenon.

Yet no matter how grave the present educational situation, the problem is not just an a posteriori one. Rather, on a less pedagogical and more properly theoretical and methodological level, we might say that the a priori conditions for the possibility of the eightfold functional specialties can be established. In the first place, theology operates in two phases,¹² and there are various ways by which one might express them. Three will be symbolized here: In biblical categories, one “listens” to the word in the first and bears witness to it in the second. In medieval categories, one would describe the movement as that from the *lectio* (reading) to the *quaestio* (or technical questions raised by and to the readings). In more contemporary categories, one would describe the historically conscious Christian theologian as, first, encountering his past and then taking his stand toward the future.¹³ The first phase, then (research-interpretation-history-dialectic), is an attempt to delineate how one encounters the Judaeo-Christian past in its multi-

¹² The division is, of course, Lonergan’s own. Still, the present writer considers it basically useful for analyzing the history of theology in its various periods, as he hopes to document historically in a book on the history of theological method in the new *Catholic Theological Encyclopedia*. It is to be noted how much more developed the analysis is than the comparatively underdeveloped treatment of the “*via inventionis*” and “*via doctrinae*” in, e.g., Lonergan’s *De Deo Trino II* (Romae, 1964), pp. 33–54.

¹³ Exactly how we may be said to “encounter” the past is one of the most difficult theoretical issues facing the contemporary theologian. It need not assume a romantic hermeneutic. Indeed, it is the issue assumed by exegetes, historians, and dogmaticians and explicated by the “hermeneutic” school; and by Lonergan via the functional specialty called dialectics.

dimensional, genetic-dialectic development, while the second (from one's articulation of one's foundations through doctrines, systematics, and communication) is one's own attempt to speak to the present and the impending future from within a basic Christian theological horizon.

In the second place, the four levels proper to each phase are correlative, for Lonergan, to the four functional and invariant levels of consciousness uncovered and thematized by transcendental method. Those four levels of consciousness, as analyzed in *Insight*, pursue four distinct but interrelated goals; for in either the spontaneous inquiry of common sense or the methodical labor of science the authentic inquirer always moves through four levels: he tries to establish the data (experience); he then tries to understand them (understanding); he next attempts to establish, with as high a degree of probability as possible, the facts (judgment); and finally, he may make his own decision on what is to be done about his knowledge (decision-action). Common sense, it is true, pursues all four without sharply distinguishing among them. Scientific inquiry, on the contrary, consciously uses all four levels first in pursuit of the first end (what are the data?); then in pursuit of the second; then of the third; and then of the fourth. And as the scientist moves to the second, third, and fourth levels, he must allow each level to function with the operations proper to that level. Once again, but now more exactly,¹⁴ Lonergan would seem to be involved in *Insight's* moving viewpoint to ever higher viewpoints.

Accordingly, if the relationship of these eight functional specialties to the fourfold levels of the structure of Lonergan's transcendental method is basically clear,¹⁵ a further clarity may be brought to bear on the discussion by elaborating the more exact meaning of each specialty in the common Christian theological enterprise. The aim of this discussion, moreover, will not be exhaustive but suggestive, not explanatory but descriptive.¹⁶

¹⁴ "More exactly" insofar as it is differentiated in accordance with the actually existing theological specialties rather than simply providing general heuristic norms for "positive," "dogmatic," and "systematic" theology (as in *De Deo Trino*).

¹⁵ This perhaps presumptuous claim is based on the hope that *Insight's* argument for human consciousness as a self-structuring process of experience, understanding, judgment, and decision is by now well known.

¹⁶ It is important to emphasize the descriptive and nonexplanatory nature of this interpretation: indeed, in Lonergan's own forthcoming method, a general context will discuss these notions more explanatorily, and a separate extended section on each of the specialties will determine their nature (for Lonergan) explanatorily. At the present writing, only the first four sections have been so analyzed (thus leaving the crucial "foundations" still to be done).

First, research. The textual critic, for example, will determine with as high a degree of scientific probability as possible just what the relevant data of the Christian message and the Christian tradition are. In short, he will strive to establish (by all the scientific means available to him) critical editions of all relevant Christian texts.¹⁷

Second, interpretation. The exegete will first presuppose the relevant data established by the textual critic; he will next recognize that the data in question are not simply “givens” (as in the empirical sciences) but involve and indeed are constituted by “meanings.” He will then attempt to establish as accurately as possible and by means of all the scientific tools available to him (parallel texts, form criticism, redaction criticism, etc.) the precise meaning of the texts under discussion.¹⁸

Third, history.¹⁹ The historian will first presuppose the meaning

¹⁷ For example, Stephen Neill cites how the controversy on the authenticity of the Ignatian epistles could only be settled (in the Baur vs. Lightfoot controversy) on the basis of exhaustive research into the texts (see Stephen Neill, *The Interpretation of the New Testament, 1861–1961* [New York, 1964], p. 47).

¹⁸ It is important to recognize the limited notion of hermeneutic employed by Lonergan here, namely, dealing with the understanding of the texts and not with the myriad of problems (critical history, historicity, empathy, etc.) ordinarily associated with that discipline (e.g., in Fuchs, Ebeling, Robinson, Funk, Hart, et al.), and precisely because Lonergan believes it to be more helpful to treat those (for him) differentiated questions distinctly. For the fuller complexities of Lonergan’s notion of hermeneutic, see his 1962 Toronto lecture, “Hermeneutics” (notes for lectures, Theology Institute, Regis College, Toronto, July 20, 1962). Whether Lonergan resolves the problems associated with hermeneutics in history and dialectics is a further problem, an important but a further question. A specific theological example of his notion of hermeneutics would be a commentary on any work of Scripture or his own hermeneutics of Aquinas’s theology of grace. Compare the hermeneutics lecture, for example, to the earlier formulation of *Insight* (pp. 562–95), and note both its fundamental continuity (e.g., the emphasis on cognitional theory) and the development (e.g., the emphasis on the context of the *Geisteswissenschaften* and historical consciousness and analysis of the German discussion of hermeneutics as “to a great extent coincident with the problems of method in contemporary Catholic theology”) (“Hermeneutics,” p. 2).

¹⁹ The problem with “history” is, of course, still more complicated than hermeneutics. Once again the section here merely indicates Lonergan’s fundamental notion of where and how the specialty “history” fits into the general collaborative theological enterprise; its actual development in explanatory detail (and Lonergan’s own critique of such figures as Troeltsch, Collingwood, Marrou, Becker, Heussi, et al.) is to be attempted in *Method*. For an earlier version, see “Hermeneutics,” esp. pp. 11–12; also the 1963 lecture, “History” (unpublished), esp. pp. 2–8; and *De Verbo Incarnato*, pp. 9–14. Note, therefore, how “history is simply an expansion of these concerns” (i.e., from “hermeneutic” [another’s meaning] to “history” [genetic-dialectic development of others’ meanings]). See also “Notes from the Introductory Lecture in the Philosophy of History” (Thomas More Institute, Montreal, September 23, 1960), esp. pp. 7–14.

established by the exegetes. On his own, he will then complement their work by using the best available historical criteria to establish just what as a matter of fact actually happened in particular events, and just what was the basic movement going forward through all the varied interpretations used to communicate that event or series of events. To use an intentionally “outrageous” example, an interpreter may interpret the assassination of Julius Caesar in a way which praises Brutus, or in a way which favors Caesar, or in a way which concludes that both of them were simply creatures of deeper economic, sociological, or cultural forces. But the historian must see to it that no one attempts to interpret that event in a manner which has Caesar killing Brutus. In other words, there remains a ground of historical factuality which may not be interpreted away by even the most brilliant exegesis. And that ground is uncovered by the critical judgment of the authentic historian as he attempts to determine as accurately as possible (e.g., the Warren Commission Report and its critics or Trevor-Roper’s *The Last Days of Hitler*) the ascertainable facts (i.e., the reality) of the event which provoked so many various interpretations. To return to a more theological context, anyone familiar with the intricacies involved in historical discussion of the meaning and/or factual status of the infancy narratives in the gospels or the far more complex resurrection narratives²⁰ will be fully familiar with the importance of the distinction employed here. It would be well to reconsider, however, how crucial for Lonergan it is to differentiate the meaning element on the level of understanding-interpretation from the matter-of-fact, “true meaning” element on the level of judgment-history. Without such a differentiation, the theologian’s need for critical historical work and, in its limit, for the historical events of the Christian tradition itself, may collapse under the heavy burden of a thousand interpretations.

Indeed, the still further differentiation of this level of judgment-history from the level of decision becomes even more crucial in contemporary theology as the *Histoire-Geschichte* debate more than suggests. For as that debate developed, one witnessed a somewhat distressing scene: on the one hand, the seeming inability of several Roman Catholic and Anglican biblical and doctrinal scholars to rise to the

²⁰ For example, one of the most startling (and, to this interpreter, ill-fated) attempts in contemporary theology is Wolfhart Pannenberg’s attempt (it would seem) practically to ground eschatological faith in the resurrection via historical reason (as performed by the Pannenberg circle) (see Wolfhart Pannenberg, *Jesus, God and Man* [Philadelphia, 1968], esp. pp. 53–115).

decision level of Bultmann's discussion of history as *Geschichte*; on the other hand, the spectacle of the incapacity of many existentialist theologians to appreciate either the discomfort of their "salvation-history" or doctrinal colleagues or the possible epistemological ambiguities of their own decision-emphasis position.²¹ In purely theological terms, therefore, the epistemological-ontological status one accords the role of judgment is crucial. It is especially crucial for a religious tradition (the Judaeo-Christian) which has traditionally insisted that its religious stance is grounded in certain historical facts. For example, if a theologian is still operating within the horizon of a Kantian epistemology,²² the role of judgment is considered merely synthetic and thereby not really distinct from the level of understanding-interpretation. Hence there is not a clearly differentiated functional specialty for historical study, and historical facts tend to be subsumed either by the exigencies of straightforward exegesis ("the Jesus of history") or the more radical exigencies of existentialist decision ("the Christ of faith"). But if the theologian is operating within the horizon of a critically realistic epistemology,²³ the level of reflective conscious-

²¹ Amidst the vast literature on this question, for a clear, brief example of both positions on the Christian stance vis-à-vis the Old Testament, see Bernhard Anderson, ed., *The Old Testament and Christian Faith* (New York, 1969), the essays, *inter alia*, by Rudolf Bultmann (pp. 8–36), Alan Richardson (pp. 36–49), Eric Voegelin (pp. 64–90), Oscar Cullmann (pp. 115–24), and James Robinson (pp. 124–59). In New Testament studies, the most obvious example would be the varying positions taken on Luke's "historicization" of the kerygma by either the Bultmann school (e.g., Conzelmann and Käsemann) as contrasted to either the Pannenberg (e.g., Wilckens) or the Cullmann school.

²² Hence the renewed importance of Lonergan's analysis of the nature of judgment as "virtually unconditioned" (see *Insight*, pp. 279–81). For Lonergan's analysis of Kant on this point, see *ibid.*, pp. 339–42; for the Kantian influence on nineteenth- and twentieth-century Protestant theology, see, *inter alia*, James Richmond, *Faith and Philosophy* (London, 1966).

²³ For example, it would seem that Schubert Ogden's Whiteheadian realism (via the "reformed" subjectivist principle) frees him from this difficulty while still allowing him to accept (as the present writer does) the major Bultmannian insistence on the need for demythologizing (see S. Ogden, *The Reality of God* [New York, 1966], esp. the essays "Theology and Objectivity" [pp. 71–99] and "Myth and Truth" [pp. 99–120]); for a contrary interpretation on Ogden from the "hermeneutic" school, see Robert W. Funk, *Language, Hermeneutic and Word of God* [New York, 1966], esp. pp. 82–108). For the present writer, Ogden's Whiteheadian position provides a far more considerable development on the Bultmannian position of objectivity (and on foundations) than do the positions more usually identified as "post-Bultmannian." For two distinct German representatives on the question of objectifying language, see R. Funk and J. Ebeling, eds., *Distinctive Protestant and Catholic Themes Reconsidered* (New York, 1967), pp. 112–36 (Heinrich Ott), pp. 136–52 (Fritz Buri).

ness and judgment is precisely the distinct level where truth-reality-historical fact (and the consequent functional specialty, history) emerge.

Fourth, dialectic. But the theologian's work does not cease after he has established the data, the interpretations, and the historical facts and perspectives as best he can. For, as every student of theology knows only too well, debates rage on every one of the prior three levels. There are, in the first place, different selections of data: Is Scripture alone the data relevant to Christian inquiry? Or does there exist a tradition which must also be studied? If the second, then what is that tradition and what is its relationship to the Scriptures? Are they really one? Or distinct and separate? And, still more important, do there also exist other, less immediately "Christian" data which are still relevant to Christian inquiry?

In the second place, there are many different interpretations of the same data. To name only the most obvious, there exist a Lutheran, a Calvinist, an Anabaptist, an Anglican, a Roman Catholic, an Orthodox interpretation of the same New Testament data. Each of these interpretation's histories, in its turn, contains a whole history of past and present differing interpretations of the same data and an entire series of prophetic witnesses to the Christian fact. In such a context, the only way that the historically conscious contemporary theologian can remain faithful to the demands of his discipline is to operate within a critically ecumenical context.²⁴ And in such an enterprise there must occur a common and serious study of at least all the major interpretations, histories, and witnesses of the Christian faith in their genetic-dialectic unfolding. Now this is not to argue for what Albert Outler has aptly named the "hand-holding" stage of ecumenism as the final answer. Nor is it to suggest that the "indifferentism" which the classically minded in all our communities are forever warning us against is the only possible result of a non-apologetic but dialectical ecumenical enterprise. But it is to insist that the historical moment of polemical apologetics is spent. And that the moment for the emergence of a specific functional specialty for theology, on the level of deliberation-evaluation-decision, which will attempt to articulate dialectically and order all the major Christian

²⁴ This is not to claim that the apologetic aim is now spent. In fact, the present writer would agree with Langdon Gilkey in his observations on the subject (*Concilium* [New York, 1969], 46:127-57). The simple point here is the need for postpolemical apologetics of a dialectically ecumenical kind.

positions in their significant similarities and differences, must now be forged.²⁵

It is, moreover, the level of dialectic which impels the theologian to investigate the phenomenon of faith and decision. For with Bultmann, Lonergan wishes to insist upon the utter radicality of the Christian faith's demands and upon the historical uniqueness²⁶ of Christian conversion as an existential phenomenon. But more dialectically than Bultmann, he also insists that the faith-decision be studied as such only after an in-depth collaborative study of the dialectical context wherein the various Christian interpretations, histories, and witnesses have been scrupulously examined. Then, Lonergan insists, the conversion experience as proper to the theologian could be experienced and articulated in a wider and deeper context than the German Protestant context has thus far allowed.²⁷ Moreover, that dialectical discussion should be further expanded (as it is at present in the United States) to allow for the intrinsic entry of the disciplines of comparative religion²⁸ and, especially, the demands of the present Jewish-Christian dialectical dialogue.

To conclude on a more positive note, the functional specialty, "dialectic," is Lonergan's effort toward a scientific way of dealing with

²⁵ In fact, dialectics is a technical and differentiated designation for a fairly widespread practice among contemporary theologians. Recall, for example, how large a part of contemporary theological works are devoted to such articulation of significant similarities and differences (indeed, sometimes with little space left for the articulation of one's position). For such examples of dialectics, see, *inter alia*, Van Harvey, *The Historian and the Believer* (New York, 1966), pp. 3–246; or Jurgen Moltmann, *The Theology of Hope* (New York, 1965), pp. 15–95; or Aloys Grillmeier, *Christ in Christian Tradition* (New York, 1965).

²⁶ For the briefest presentation of Bultmann's position, besides the "classic" texts, see R. Bultmann, *Existence and Faith* (New York, 1966), esp. pp. 55–58, 92–111, 298. The word "uniqueness" is, I realize, vague (insofar as Socrates, too, is "unique"). However, the present context is not the proper one to attempt to determine more exactly that unique nature of the claims in a manner neither Barthian nor Bultmannian (nor Lonerganian).

²⁷ The "German Protestant" context is cited since for the present writer it remains the most erudite contemporary theological tradition and, therefore, helps one to understand how it can dialectically be transformed to be both "wider" (i.e., as dialectically ecumenical) and deeper (e.g., by developing some of the secular philosophical sophistication and empirical verification demands of much of the recent American Protestant theological tradition or of the Catholic transcendental methodologists [Continental and American]).

²⁸ For specific examples of such "dialectics," see the series of the "Chicago School," *Essays in Divinity*, ed. Jerald Brauer, esp. vol. 2, *The Impact of the Church upon Its Culture* (Chicago, 1968); and Eliade-Kitagawa, *The History of Religions Essays in Methodology* (Chicago, 1962).

the religious event called “conversion,”²⁹ from which theology for him may speak authentically. At that level, the theologian has the opportunity to encounter the religious situation as it is now and as it has been in a past mediated to him³⁰ by his dialectical involvement with the authentic Christian traditions.

At the level of decision-dialectic-conversion, therefore, the theological task proper to “hearing,” to “*lectio*,” to encountering the Christian past is attempted. But still there can be no cessation of labor for the theologian, for the effort of thematization of that conversion experience is yet to come. In short, it is time to initiate discussion of the next functional specialty, foundations.

²⁹ Hence the reinforced centrality afforded the category of “conversion” (intellectual, moral, and religious) in Lonergan’s later work (see *De Methodo Theologiae* [notes for lectures at Gregorian University, 1962], pp. 3–5; “Theology in Its New Context,” *Theology of Renewal*, 1: 44–51). Lonergan has yet to determine what for this interpreter remains the most difficult theological question for the Christian theologian, namely, the relationship between “religious” and “Christian” conversions. His Christology (*De Verbo Incarnato*), it should be recalled, was written before the emphasis in his thought on dialectics and foundations (with the exception of the last “thesis” to be written at that time on the *Existenz* of Christ, *De Verbo Incarnato* [Rome, 1964], pp. 332–416). His methodological work continues to attempt to work out the significant dialectical similarities and differences of religious conversion (e.g., the Lonerganian interpretation of Friedrich Heiler’s “The History of Religions as a Preparation for the Cooperation of Religions,” in Eliade-Kitagawa, pp. 142–53), but not yet (to my knowledge) of explicitly Christian conversion. Perhaps the reason for this position is that the traditional emphasis in Catholic theology upon the universal salvific will of God and the emphasis on philosophy’s role in theology rarely tend to the “exclusivity” dilemmas of the Barthian (or even the Bultmannian) positions. (The Rahner–von Balthasar exchange on “anonymous Christianity” may prove to be an important exception to this generalization.) For an interesting dialectical contrast of the Catholic and Protestant positions on “religion,” see the Lonergan-influenced article, Joseph A. Komonchak, “The Problem of a Religious A Priori,” *Dunwoody Review* 7 (1967): 199–214.

³⁰ “Mediation of tradition” becomes, therefore, a crucial theological task as a factor emphasized in contemporary theology not only by such Catholic theologians as Rahner and Lonergan, but also by such contemporary Protestant theologians as Ebeling and Pannenberg (via Gadamer’s hermeneutic of merging horizons). The openness to the “future” mentioned by Lonergan as another task on the level of dialectics is not, to my knowledge, ever attempted by him, especially, it must be added, on the question of eschatology (which receives scant notice in Lonergan’s entire work. For example, the lack of such emphasis in Lonergan’s recent essay “The Future of Christianity,” *Holy Cross Quarterly* [1969], pp. 5–10). Whether this need lead to a critique of Lonergan’s transcendental method like that accorded to Rahner by John Baptist Metz is a further question. As I have tried to indicate elsewhere (“Horizon Analysis and Eschatology,” *Continuum* [Summer 1968]), it need not (even though Lonergan’s lack of explicitation cannot be accepted). For a possibly contrary view on Lonergan and political-social realities, see Michael Novak, *The Theology of Radical Politics* (New York, 1969), and contrast it with his earlier “Lonerganian” work *Belief and Unbelief* (New York, 1965).

Fifth, foundations. The role of foundations for Lonergan is to objectify conversion into a basic horizon.³¹ As the category “conversion” is central to the level of dialectic, so, technically formulated, “horizon” is to the level of foundations.³² A “horizon,” technically formulated, is a maximum field of vision from a determinate standpoint with objective and subjective poles, each one of which is determined by and determines the other. A basic horizon, moreover, possesses a basic subjective pole (intellectual, moral, religious, and specifically Christian conversions) and an objective pole (as the thematization of those conversions). Foundational theology, then, attempts to articulate the basic horizon from within which a theologian operates. In Roman Catholic theology, the uniqueness of this conception of foundational theology might best be studied by comparing it with traditional Catholic “fundamental” theology. That latter discipline, with its convenient lists of various questions (inspiration, the mission of Christ, revelation, etc.) was helpful enough as a pedagogical device but never really got to the core of anything that could be called a genuinely “fundamental” theology. Its confines were both too narrow (the separate questions, the apologetic atmosphere, the failure to engage in the necessary preliminary research, interpretation, history, and dialectic) and too superficial (as student malaise testifies) to allow for the development of a foundational theological horizon. Indeed the widespread retreat from *theoria* to activism among many theological students is not fully explicable, I suspect, in terms of a general contemporary phenomenon alone. Rather it may well expose the presence of a general, often inchoate, and usually undifferentiated repugnance with the seeming lack of any fundamental intellectual, moral, and religious seriousness in much of what passes for “fundamental” theology. In effect, then, the students may be demanding of the theologians what they might long ago have demanded of themselves: that they critically and theoretically examine and expose their presuppositions, their methods, their categories, and then attempt to thematize them. That demand has

³¹ Hence the importance of the issue of objectivization-thematization; specifically, for Lonergan, the importance of his thematization of the invariant norms, structures, and procedures of intellectual conversion in *Insight*; and of his recent (and still incomplete) attempts to achieve the thematization of moral and religious conversion on the level of *Existenz*.

³² The clearest published expression of the category remains “Metaphysics as Horizon” (*Collection*, pp. 202–21). Note that the critical effort is one of thematizing the unthematic (preconceptual, etc.), not of Cartesian doubt (see *Insight*, pp. xxi–xxiii, 408–11). For Lonergan’s own foundational theology, one should examine not only his former work in doctrine and transcendental method but also the sections on “religion” and the “question of God” in the forthcoming *Method in Theology*.

forced most theologians to realize the simple historical necessity of the kind of radical theological rethinking now occurring throughout the Christian world.³³ It invites them to enter into that horizon-problematic and try to bring the Christian fact to speech again and to do so by a careful theoretical thematization of the language and meaning of their own values, beliefs, faith. And whether one's horizon be most adequately thematized in terms of the *existentia* of the early Heidegger or the language event of the later; of the process philosophy of Whitehead and Hartshorne or of Hegelian and Nietzschean language; of the expansion of the transcendental method in Rahner or the later Lonergan; or of some other as yet untried foundation, is an urgent but here a further question.³⁴ And I do not propose to digress from the

³³ If one may repeat a needed emphasis: such radical theological thinking (whether named "death of God," secularity, etc.) is imperative at present, and only those unaware of the difficulties involved with the recognition of the "historicity" of the individual theologian can afford the luxury of surprise and "shock" at the seemingly chaotic theological situation. For a helpful summary of the meaning of "historicity" and its implications for philosophy (and, although the author does not so argue, for theology as well), see Emil Fackenheim, *Metaphysics and Historicity* [Milwaukee, 1961].

³⁴ That crucial issue, as I interpret it, may be stated thus: (a) how does one most adequately formulate the foundational question (e.g., via a "transcendental" formulation on the conditions of possibility of transcendence experience and language or a "Heideggerian" formulation on the ontological status of the finite, historical speaker of such discourse or a Whiteheadian, etc.), and (b) what are the criteria (logical coherence, adequacy, etc.) for the thematized conceptualities emerging from the preferred manner of thematization (e.g., Hartshorne's and Ogden's critiques of the conceptuality of the God of classical theism or Lonergan's critique of the unverifiability of the Molinist *scientia media* theory)? Although Lonergan does not so explicitly differentiate these questions, it would seem to this interpreter that he should, otherwise they can rather easily become almost totally undifferentiated (as, for example, in much of the "death of God" positions or of the activist aspect of the secular-eschatological positions). And that failure of explicit differentiation can also disallow a serious treatment of the distinct question of the logical criteria for the thematized conceptualities. For example, I believe that one could accept the Hartshorne-Ogden critique of the logical inadequacies of classical theism without having to accept the Whiteheadian "reformed subjectivist principle" as the most helpful way to formulate the crucial issue of critically grounding transcendence language. Moreover, on the (a) section of the question, Ricoeur's emphasis, especially in "Existence et herméneutique," in *Interpretation der Welt* (Würzburg, 1965), that one must not (he is criticizing Heidegger) move immediately to philosophical reflections without dealing with the hermeneutics of the different human and empirical sciences seems to me entirely correct. In terms of the "foundational" question, that insistence (expanded by Ricoeur in *Histoire et vérité* [Paris, 1955]) should seem to impel Lonergan to develop his distinction between "relative" and "basic" horizon more fully than he has at present, and thus to clarify how the human sciences are related functionally to theology on the level of foundations as well as communications.

If, however, one's position is fundamentally fideist (as, for example, in some of the theological uses of Wittgenstein) then, of course, the whole issue of these questions

present methodological problem to respond to it here. For my present aim is at once more simple, more formal and, in that sense, more fundamental than the actual working out of the thematic foundations themselves. For I wish to indicate just where and how that foundational question has arisen, and that the question is not resolved either by a retreat into a classicist “fundamental” theology or by a romantic onslaught which feels free to ignore the exigencies of encountering the past (through research-interpretation-critical history and dialectic) while staking its religious and theological claims on an imagined present or future.

Sixth, doctrines. One should note, first of all, that doctrine in Lonergan’s method only becomes a properly theological question after the work of the first five theological specialties has already been accomplished. One must have developed from data through interpretation, history, dialectics, and foundations before the basic horizon is explicated whence one may understand that movement toward doctrine and system involved in the Christian community’s development from the *quoad nos* of the Scriptures to the *quoad se* of the councils.³⁵ Second, the several Christian doctrines each demands an analysis by the properly qualified textual critics, exegetes, historians, dialecticians, and foundational theologians. On the foundational level, for example, the presence of a thematized intellectual conversion is essential for understanding the nature of the doctrines.³⁶ Third, Lonergan’s placement of the specialty “doctrines” on the third level of consciousness is also of some importance.³⁷ For as with the “facts” of history, doctrines are placed by Lonergan not on the level of experience or understanding or decisions, but of judgment.³⁸ In other words, for Lonergan doctrines

seems folly. But if one will not choose the intellectual escape of fideism then one cannot flee from the foundational issue nor from a recognition of the truth in Schillebeeckx’s insistence “that the present-day crisis in faith is essentially a crisis in metaphysics” (see Edward Schillebeeckx, *God the Future of Man* [New York, 1968], p. 47).

³⁵ Note how Lonergan’s present differentiation is able to functionally relate to the *theological* disciplines.

³⁶ It is possible, for example, that the ambiguities of the neo-Orthodox tradition on the earlier question of the relationship of philosophy (or historical reason) to faith in theology led to some of the difficulties involved for that tradition in interpreting the meaning and possibilities of the conciliar period.

³⁷ Lonergan’s critique of L. Dewart for lack of same in “The Dehellenization of Dogma,” in *The Future of Belief Debate*, ed. G. Baum (New York, 1967), pp. 69–73.

³⁸ Hence the renewed importance of the critical realism of *Insight* and the insistence upon realism as foundational for the Christian (see the unpublished 1961 lecture, “The Origins of Christian Realism”).

affirm incompletely but truly (i.e., really) certain essential features of the Christian belief. Hence within the foundational horizon proper to the Christian theologian, doctrines provide the minimal judgments and affirmations proper to the Christian's belief. For even granted the limitations and present inadequacies of the classical hellenistic categories of the conciliar, patristic, and medieval periods, it still remains true that the Greek movement to *theoria* (in present categories, the movement to and from intellectual conversion) allowed the Christian community then (as it does now) to make certain reasonably clear affirmations of its basic beliefs. The argument can be clearly stated: The transposition, for example, from the nature-person categories of Chalcedon to the person as presence-in-the-world categories of a Rahner or a Schillebeeckx is a transposition which only occurs within a basic continuity with those affirmations which Christians (beginning with the New Testament "Jesus is Lord") have often made. Once again, therefore, the importance of Lonergan's analysis of judgment for his handling of the related problems of history and doctrines cannot be overemphasized.

Seventh, systematics. The nature of systematics for Lonergan is best articulated in his earlier studies of the medievals,³⁹ for there he argues that the exact nature of the medieval achievement was its articulation of a strictly technical language and of rigorously theoretical techniques aimed at clarifying and explaining the scriptural and doctrinal beliefs of the Christian community. So Père Bouillard, for example, has argued that if Aquinas had known the anti-semi-pelagianist decrees of the Council of Orange, he might have been able to resolve his early struggles with the theology of grace far more rapidly. In short, it is imperative for the theologian at the systematic level of discussion to search out a technical language that might express as clearly and distinctly as possible the nature of the realities he affirms as believer. And even if the classical categories of an Aquinas or Calvin are no longer adequate to that systematic task, this does not exempt the contemporary systematic theologian from the effort to achieve in the new scientific context what they achieved in theirs.

Eighth, communications. At this final level, the problem usually named "relevance" emerges. Indeed, here the disciplines variously named catechetics, or religious education, or ministerial theology, must find their contemporary transformation. Only certain central factors

³⁹ See Lonergan's *Verbum* (Notre Dame, 1968), pp. 206–21; and "St. Thomas Thought on *Gratia Operans*," *Theological Studies* 3 (1942): 572–78.

intrinsic to that transformation may be noted in this brief discussion. In the first place, the question of communication emerges as a properly theological question only after each of the first seven functional specialties has played its proper role. For no more than intuitionist theories can save the epistemological day, neither can romantic leaps from Jesus to the fabled man in the street (even the man at the barricades) save theology. In short, *simpliste* solutions solve nothing in the long run for they only require the eventual reemergence of the original and originating problem. In the second place, vague calls for a renewed “ministerial” theology will not suffice. Instead, theologians must learn to collaborate with the methods and results of theoreticians and practitioners in the field of communications theory, of linguistics, of comparative literature, of political theory, of psychology, of sociology, of cultural anthropology, and of the rest of the whole range of recently developed human sciences.⁴⁰ Otherwise even very good systematic theology may continue to crash against the charge of irrelevance from nontheologians (or even from other theologians, as in Cox’s sociological critique of Bultmann or Metz’s political-historical critique of Rahner). In the third place, there can be no pretense that any one theologian can master the methods of all seven previous specialties much less than he can become an expert in all the various sciences which the level of communications includes. But he can learn to collaborate with human scientists, first in a genuinely theoretical way (by learning the science in its accepted methods, procedures, and results), and only then with theological applications. That such an interdisciplinary task can be achieved in a university setting is at present more a hope, I suspect, than a reality. But one may continue to hope (especially in the light of the “proleptic” anticipations of that possibility in figures like Metz, Gilkey, Berger, et al.) that this crucial task will also someday be attempted in a genuinely collaborative way.

A. POSSIBILITIES OF FUNCTIONAL SPECIALIZATION⁴¹

The most obvious advantage of the methodical approach which

⁴⁰ Note, therefore, that this functional specialty also remains a strictly *theoretical* discipline.

⁴¹ The listing of these possibilities is fundamentally faithful to Lonergan’s own analysis in the *Gregorianum* article on functional specialties. The point is more adequately determined in the section of *Method in Theology* on religion. The further possibilities of functional specialization (especially the interrelationship of the two phases: most especially of the third and fourth levels of each phase), will also be extensively discussed there.

Lonergan develops is, I believe, its ability to order the different theological tasks. Moreover, that ordering is not merely a matter of necessary convenience, as are the various field specialties (too much data for one man) or the various subject specialties (too great a growth in all subjects for any one man to master them all). For note that the functional specialties are determined as such by their specifically different tasks: different ends, different means, different methods. The methodical theologian must constantly distinguish those eight separate tasks and keep them separate. In one form or another, all eight of those tasks demand the theologian's attention. But once theology reaches the contemporary stage of development, its two phases and the four functions of each phase become clearly differentiated.

A second advantage may also be determined; that theology may be unified without retreating into deductivism. No function for Lonergan is deduced from any others. Rather each presupposes the earlier and complements it in some clearly differentiated way. The whole process, moreover, possesses what he has elsewhere (in *Insight*) argued to be the intrinsic unity of the dynamism of human consciousness itself: from an undifferentiated state (the original faith experience) through differentiation and specialization (doctrines, systematics, and increasing specialization) to the integration of the various specialties (by the dynamic, self-structuring integration of the eight functional specialties themselves).

A third advantage also recommends itself: that functional specialization can reveal the genuine need of the contemporary differentiated consciousness for a theology. In fact, the needed differentiation between religion and theology can be apprehended adequately only by a differentiated consciousness. For only one who has himself appropriated the theoretical and critical tradition of the West can begin to appreciate that movement toward theology which began in the apostolic fathers, continued through the conciliar, patristic, medieval, and Reformation periods, and must be continued today for the still more differentiated consciousness of twentieth-century man. Otherwise, the living religious spirit which must ground all genuine theology (dialectic foundations) will become ever more suspect as the theology intended to illuminate religion increases its competence in field and subject specialties, but actually decreases its possibilities of integration and communication. It is true, of course, that wherever consciousness is not differentiated, theology as a theoretical exercise with eight functional specialties becomes incomprehensible. In fact, in that situation it is not really

needed. For all the worlds of the human horizon (e.g., profane-sacred; interior-exterior; common sense-theory⁴²) are already unified for the undifferentiated mind, and the possibilities of symbolic expression prove fully adequate to its religious needs. But whenever consciousness becomes highly differentiated, one's former childlike apprehension of religion appears childish, or at best esoteric and marginal to one's intellectual life. One soon finds oneself joining the "cultured despisers" of religion. Accordingly, unless the truly contemporary Christian adult prefers to "differentiate" his religious life only by allowing the memories of a childhood happiness to evaporate into the adventitiousness of an undifferentiated religious "atmosphere" (to which he returns only when the emotional uplift of the "God of the gaps" is desired), the adult's need to make the religious values of his life cognitively accessible becomes ever more imperative. In short, he needs a theology. It is true that the differentiation between theology and religion should occur primarily to allow a deepened return to the life of religious self-transcendence (communications-experience). But without that prior scientific differentiation the later return tends to become empty-handed and peremptory.

In that context, Lonergan's own earlier work on theory, on system, on science, on cognitional analysis, becomes ever more relevant to contemporary theology. For as Bonhoeffer has reminded us all in a manner we dare not forget, it is capricious and ultimately irresponsible for the contemporary man who affirms religious values (he would prefer simply Christian) to retreat into anything less than full involvement with the scientific, philosophical, and even technological advancements of our day.⁴³ And, as Eric Voegelin further reminds us,⁴⁴ it is imperative for the contemporary analyst of the religious phenomenon to investigate and, if possible, appropriate not only the whole range of religious phenomena which Max Weber so brilliantly analyzed, but also the two which he did not: the Greek philosophers' study of religion from the viewpoint of *theoria* and the medievals' analogous application of *theoria* to Christian interiority.

It would be well to clarify another possible source of misrepresentation: Lonergan's notion of theology as an eightfold methodically

⁴² The reader may agree with the present writer that Lonergan's own *critical* grounding of the sacred is less than adequate throughout his work.

⁴³ How full that involvement was may be recognized in the recent impressive biography by Mary Bosanquet, *The Life and Death of Dietrich Bonhoeffer* (New York, 1969).

⁴⁴ Eric Voegelin, *The New Science of Politics* (Chicago, 1952).

ordered structure does not, if I understand it correctly, impose some new Lonerganian “system” upon theology, but rather allows it to explicate the essentially open and heuristic structure which theology already is. That heuristic openness, furthermore, must be present on every level of theology’s development: research is always open to further relevant data; interpretation to deeper penetration; history to firmer affirmations and wider narrative perspectives; dialectic to expansion and more accurate clarification of the real similarities and differences between positions; foundations to more exacting thematization; doctrines to greater development; systematics to more rigorous technical expression; communications to the discovery of new fields (e.g., McLuhan et al.); and the improvement of the already existing human sciences. Moreover, each level is also open to further development insofar as each is functionally related to all the others and thereby reciprocally dependent upon them. For example, interpretation is obviously dependent on research, but the reverse is also true: a new method of interpretation can bring about different determinations of the original data. Dialectics is obviously dependent on research, interpretation, and history, but once again the reverse is true: for example, as the ecumenical dialectic widens and deepens the level of discussion exemplified in the Hans Küng–Ernst Käsemann exchange on the New Testament foundations of “early Catholicism”⁴⁵ will demand more probing research, interpretation, and history on the first three levels. Or, as the problem of communication accelerates, there is bound to emerge a John A. T. Robinson or a William Hamilton to raise issues and demand clarifications that should force anyone operating in any of the first seven functional specialties to more exacting labors. As such functional interrelationship develops, each specialist may learn to curb his own temptations to omniscience as he listens to and learns from his colleagues in the other specialties. And if theologians can begin to collaborate in that functional way, then the whole series of possibly unnecessary impasses (dogmatic versus biblical theology; “relevance” versus theory; “dialogue” versus foundations) which have tended to dominate much of the theological horizon since the entry of historical consciousness into theology may finally become past history. In its unmourned place, a truly collaborative and contemporaneously scientific theological enterprise might be initiated.

Finally, a second kind of reciprocal interdependence should be noted:

⁴⁵ Ernest Käsemann, *Essays on New Testament Themes* (London, 1964), pp. 63, 233–74.

the dependence of the two phases on one another. It is hardly necessary, I suppose, to insist upon the dependence of the second phase (“mediated theology”) upon the first (“mediating theology”), but it might prove helpful to spell out that dependence in greater detail. The first phase, then, for Lonergan mediates theology by transforming the field specialties into functional specialties which, on the level of dialectic, finally mediate the Christian conversion that grounds any authentically theological Christian horizon. All first-phase questions must be met not by any appeal to the second phase as an *a priori* (e.g., Aquinas’s use of Aristotelian categories in his commentaries on the scriptures or, at times, Bultmann’s use of the Heideggerian *existentialia* for his hermeneutic) but out of the resources of the first phase itself.

On the other hand, the second phase must obviously be dependent on the first. Otherwise, the difficulties all too familiar to those who have endured the “proof-text” methods of the manuals, or even the inspiring but scientifically somewhat capricious “spiritual” hermeneutics of Alexandria or, more recently, Karl Barth,⁴⁶ will again emerge to fashion theologies with too tenuous a connection with their Christian sources. But once that dependence is clearly established, the exigencies represented by the prophetic *and* theological demands of a Barth—that theology be concerned with God and all things in their relationship to God—can be met without falling into Barth’s theological disdain for the earlier exigencies of the historico-critical method (phase one). For those former exigencies are properly resolved only by the full development of the second phase as it descends from the horizon of thematized Christian conversion through doctrines and systematics to communication.

Such interdependence of the two phases, moreover, is especially crucial on the third and fourth levels. On the third level (judgment-history-doctrine)⁴⁷ there is always an intrinsic interdependence between the specialist in doctrines and the specialist in doctrinal

⁴⁶ A fascinating example of the kind of impasse occasioned by such misunderstanding may be found in the recently published Barth-Harnack exchange, *Continuum* 7 (1969): 195–213 (also in J. Robinson, ed., *The Beginnings of Dialectic Theology* [Richmond, Va., 1969], pp. 165–91).

⁴⁷ It is on this level that most of the Catholic discussions on “development of doctrine” have been conducted. For a useful survey of this, see Charles N. Bent, *Interpreting the Doctrine of God* (New York, 1968); for specific examples, *Lo Sviluppo del dogma secondo la dottrina cattolica* (Rome, 1953); for a similar approach from a Protestant author, Jaroslav Pelikan, *Development of Christian Doctrine: Some Historical Prolegomena* (New Haven, Conn., 1969).

history (as, for example, in Lonergan's own work on Christology). To employ a nontheological example, it is easy enough for anyone to grasp that one dare not write a history of physics unless he already understands present physical theory. Conversely, he cannot fully understand contemporary physical theory unless he has made some study of the history of its development. Similarly, as the recent controversies in the Roman Catholic world on transubstantiation testify, one cannot hope to understand the doctrines as other than verbal formulas unless one first understands the history of their emergence.⁴⁸ But understanding that history demands some prior apprehension of the doctrines themselves. For example, if the theologian did not already possess some understanding of the notions of procession, relation, and person, he could not hope to write a history of Trinitarian development that could avoid the pitfalls of entirely missing certain key factors, of over-emphasizing minor points and, in general, confusing rather than clarifying that complex issue.

On the fourth level, moreover, there is a yet more radical interdependence between the specialties dialectics and foundations, for the foundational theologian attempts to objectify authentically Christian religious conversion as it emerges from dialectical discussion. And while there may well be more than one account of authentic conversion, dialectics yet may hope to reveal certain fundamental similarities among the differences. That revelation, in its turn, may tend to reduce the multiplicity exposed in the earlier stages of dialectic and eliminate merely polemical and apologetic tendencies. Hence, the thematization proper to foundations will not be left to the caprice of a *Weltanschauung* or the merely private religious experience of the foundational theologian. In fact, may not the attempts of Bultmann and Tillich and those who followed them legitimately be interpreted as major efforts to break out of the religiously rigid confines of the Barthian dialectical system? And was not their limited but real success due to their attempts to establish deeper contact with what Lonergan has called the level of conversion-dialectic? Does not Bultmann's exegetical work reveal a deeper realization than Barth ever possessed of the theologian's need for fidelity to the first three functional specialties? Or does not Tillich's dialogue with the contemporary human sciences reveal a greater sensitivity to the pressing need for what we have

⁴⁸ For a clear summary and example, see Edward Schillebeeckx, *The Eucharist* (New York, 1968).

called the functional specialty “communications”?⁴⁹ Admittedly, both Bultmann’s and Tillich’s theologies can now be recognized as inadequate. But that is not really the point at issue here. Rather, both their partial success and their distinct failures serve to illustrate the nature of theology conceived as functional specialization. Their partial success reveals the genuine integrity of their realization of the need to attempt some kind of integration of what Lonergan calls field (phase one) and subject (phase two) specializations on the level of dialectics and foundations. For the collapse of all classical theological systems or even the ultimate failure of the modern Barthian, Bultmannian and Tillichian attempts at theological integration do not argue for the impossibility of any attempt at integration. To be more specific, their failure should not argue against careful attention by all theologians (in whatever discipline, of whatever tradition) to the possibly more sophisticated, if at present purely formal, principles of theological integration afforded by Lonergan’s notion of theology as comprised of eight functional specializations. For the dynamic unity and the integrating power of functional specialization is composed of the interaction of those two phases and those eight functional specialties which, as a unitive whole, define for Lonergan contemporary theology. Moreover, that notion of theology, he argues, finds its basic heuristic structure verified in the transcendental method of *Insight* and thus allows for the dynamic, self-structuring method of functional specialization. Finally, it demands and makes methodologically possible the intrinsic interaction of religion and theology (dialectics-foundations) and the same kind of interaction between theology and the world (the first seven specialties and communications).⁵⁰

CONCLUSION

Hence, I believe that the “possibilities” of Lonergan’s notion of theology as a self-structuring unity comprised of eight functional specialties

⁴⁹ The example of Tillich in his attempt to resolve the totality of the theological enterprise strikes this reader as unparalleled among theologians for the ambitiousness of the task he was willing to undertake up to the final lectures, where he seems willing to revise his entire notion of systematics in the light of his study of the history of religions (see *The Future of Religion* [New York, 1966])!

⁵⁰ One should compare this development, for example, not only with the early and very general methodological precepts of the 1959 *De Intellectu et Methodo* but also with the more refined but still unintegrated concerns and categories of the 1962 *De Methodo Theologiae*, or the 1964 Georgetown lectures on method.

are real and could prove fruitful for a genuinely collaborative theological enterprise. But the difficulties with his position are also quite real. Allow me to close this discussion with at least a brief articulation of one major difficulty, namely, what is the meaning of “foundational” as applied to foundational theology here? Does it refer simply to a dialectical integration and explicitation of the actually existing Christian tradition (no small task, to be sure) or does it also and distinctly refer (as factors such as “transcendental method” or “basic horizon” would seem to indicate) to the need radically to question the groundedness (or, to employ the transcendental vocabulary, the transcendental conditions of the possibility) of strictly religious, philosophical, and theological meaning? Indeed, if the latter problematic is not explicitly raised and if some systematic resolution is not attempted, I fear that one must judge the enterprise methodologically extremely valuable as a differentiating and integrating (i.e., collaborative) force for traditional Christian theologies but not as genuinely foundational for the contemporary task. I realize, however, that to offer this criticism fairly to Lonergan one must (a) state in some detail precisely what one understands himself as *the* foundational problematic in postcumenical contemporary theology; (b) examine Lonergan’s past attempts to resolve the critical issues philosophically (*Insight*) and theologically (e.g., Lonergan’s interpretation of Aquinas’s “theorem” of divine transcendence); (c) study Lonergan’s present work on the nature of religion and conversion more carefully; and (d) await the specific section on “foundations” in the forthcoming *Method*. Yet even granted all that, the problem must still, I believe, be raised of any explicitly “contemporary” theological position, especially one which attempts a “foundational” response to the issues which beset us all. That I have merely raised the question here, I am aware.⁵¹ My own articulation of the question itself and my own interpretation of Lonergan on that question must, however, await another time and another context.⁵² For if the present article has succeeded at all in communicating those prior important and more purely methodological interests, its more modest aim has been more than satisfied.

⁵¹ And that the present article has been merely descriptive, not explanatory of them, is likewise true.

⁵² That context will be the present writer’s historical-critical article on “Lonergan on Foundations” for the spring Lonergan congress.